

All-American (Fox Hunt)

Chapter 1

Tuesday, June 1st - 3 days until Jack's birthday

A warm summer breeze floated in through the open window of the office, accompanied by a ray of golden sunlight as the clouds parted way for the sun to shine. Jack sat idly in a big comfy armchair, the blue and white blazer wrapping itself loosely around his somewhat thin frame. He stared up at the painting to his right, which hung on the dark oak wood wall, slightly crooked. Depicted upon the painting was the image of lamb, laying underneath the watchful gaze of a singular eye, one that hung high in the cloudy midnight sky, casting light as if it were the sun itself—or perhaps equating it to the moon would be more appropriate given the time of night the painting took place.

Jack's thoughts of lambs and eyes were swiftly cut off by the sound of creaking wood and swinging hinges. A short and stout man entered the room, dressed formally enough, but with his tie slightly undone as to invite a sense of casualness. He gave Jack a big smile as he saw the boy turn around to greet him, and made his way to the back of the room.

"Sorry to keep you waiting kid, you know how talkative Mrs. Foster can get," the man said with a hearty chuckle, one which Jack reciprocated out of politeness. "So!" he continued, letting out a grunt as he dropped himself into an armchair identical to Jack's, leaning forward to more give an air of personability (it definitely helped that the doctor almost looked young enough to be a student himself). "How's it been going man? How's your week been?" Jack leaned back a little in his seat, crossing his legs to set himself at ease as his gaze shifted down from the man in front of him to the large maple desk between the two.

"Uh... it's been pretty good I guess. I've mainly just been doing homework and practicing for the game this week." Jack felt comfortable around Dr. Hayworth, at least, as comfortable as he felt around anyone. It had only been a few months since he had expressed his desire to talk to a therapist to his parents, and although he was unsure about talking to a school therapist, Hayworth seemed to be pretty understanding of his anxieties.

"What about friends? You mentioned last week that Haley had invited you to dinner with her parents, didn't you?" Hayworth asked, taking out a notebook and pencil as he prepared to take notes on what Jack said.

"Oh right! That got pushed back to this Thursday." Although Jack had been dating Haley for close to five months now, he had still not yet met her parents. Part of the blame for that could be put onto Jack, as he was nervous to spend an entire evening talking to the people whose daughter he was eager to hook up with, however he figured that thought was more likely a result of natural teenage nervousness than his general paranoia.

"I see, not because of you I hope?" Hayworth said with a grin as he scribbled something down in his notebook. Jack let out a slight smile, shaking his head in the negative.

"Nah, her dad just got the flu the day before, so we had to push the dinner back." Hayworth smiled and nodded as he continued to scribble in his notebook. Jack's slight smirk turned down as he remembered the main topic he had wanted to bring up with the therapist that week. "Oh right, and umm... I've been having the dream about the fox hunt again," Jack's right leg found itself bobbing up and down nervously, a bad habit he had developed as a kid. Hayworth's smile faltered as well as he turned the page of the notebook.

"I see, was anything different this time around?" he asked, readying his pencil. Jack looked away from the man, back at the painting of the lamb, before clearing his throat to respond.

"N-no, well... kinda I guess. Haley was there this time, along with some more people I know from school," Jack said softly, placing a hand on his leg to keep it in place, though this only led to his left leg shaking up and down in its place.

"And, were your friends being hunted as well, or were they with your parents, hunting you?" Hayworth said inquisitively, the sound of pencil scratching against paper sounding out throughout the office.

"They were with my parents, hunting 'fox me'," Jack said with a nervous chuckle, still feeling rather silly explaining the dream, despite having done so plenty of times before. "I know you said it's probably just a reaction to hunting with my dad for the first time, but I'm not sure. I've been having this dream for a few weeks now, and it doesn't make sense for my friends to be a part of it." This was the third week in a row that Jack had remembered having the dream. When he first told Hayworth about it, he had shrugged it off as nothing more than a somewhat extreme reaction to Jack shooting his first deer the week prior, as Jack's father had started taking him hunting in preparation for his 18th birthday. However, Jack had always been unhappy with this assessment of things, it was one of the few things he and Hayworth seemed to really disagree on. Jack let out a soft sigh as he slouched down in his seat, letting his leg succumb to its desire to nervously shake. Hayworth ceasing his writing, frowned softly as Jack said this, and paused to think for a moment before responding.

"Well, perhaps hunting just had a more profound effect on you than we initially assumed. You are a good deal more sensitive than your father about these types of things," Hayworth said

with a soft chuckle, continuing before Jack could protest his evaluation of the dream's origin.

"So! Your 18th birthday is coming up next week huh? How does that feel?" Jack considered shifting the conversation back to the dream, but figured that Hayworth was probably right, he probably was just overthinking it.

"It feels good, I guess... I mean, I'm excited for the party and all, it's just that I always feel kinda guilty around this time of year," Jack said, looking down a little. Hayworth raised an eyebrow at Jack.

"What do you mean guilty?" He asked in an inquisitive tone, though one a bit more knowing than his usual cadence.

"Well, like I don't deserve it I guess. Like, it feels weird to have everyone celebrating me just... existing... if that makes any sense," Jack replied shyly, already anticipating the doctor's reaction.

"Of course you deserve it Jack! Everyone gets a birthday party, just because your parents are more outgoing with their celebration doesn't mean you deserve it any less," Hayworth said in what clearly was intended to be a kind tone, though it came off as a bit more frustrated than he probably intended.

"I know that but... I don't know... I was thinking of asking them if we could just have a small party or something, something a bit more personal." Hayworth shifted in his seat, not having written anything down in his notebook for a while at this point.

"But you love those big celebrations! They always make you so happy, and they make everyone else so happy for you. So in a way, it's rather more selfish to have a private celebration than a public one if you think about it like that," Hayworth spoke a bit faster than usual, as if this were a thought he had been mulling over for quite some time, rather than one coming off the top

of his head. Jack crossed and uncrossed his legs, feeling somewhat annoyed, this was one of the other things him and Hayworth disagreed on. Although, there were certainly aspects of a big party Jack enjoyed, and what Hayworth said seemed to make sense. Perhaps he was right, he was right about a lot of things after all, and Jack was just a high schooler with self-esteem issues, perhaps it was selfish to take a big celebration away from his parents and friends, it did certainly seem to make everyone happier. Jack nodded softly, a response to which Hayworth gave a big happy smile. "See! There's the Jack I know!"

There was a moment of silence before the doctor continued, changing the subject once again.

"Any other plans for this week?" Hayworth questioned without looking up from his notes. Jack scratched his chin before nodding and smiling.

"Yea! Jeremy and I are planning on hanging out at his place tonight, and uhh... Mark's probably gonna be there too," he said with a slight crack in his demeanor. Despite being on the school's baseball team, Jack didn't consider himself to be one of the 'jocks'. Mark on the other hand, seemed to be the antithesis of everything Jack was. He was big, confident, brash, and loud—very very loud. Despite all this, he was good friends with everyone Jack was friends with, so clearly there was something about him people liked, and who was Jack to tell his friends who and who not to spend time with.

Hayworth glanced up from his notebook, sensing the tone of disappointment in Jack's voice.

"You've mentioned before that you aren't particularly fond of Mark right?" Hayworth said in a curious tone. Jack nodded with a sigh, leaning back and letting his eyes fall to the carpeted floor beneath them.

“Yea... I don’t want to be mean to him, but I don’t know... he can just be a bit much to deal with sometimes,” Jack trailed off as Hayworth examined him.

“Well if that’s the case, then perhaps you too should talk to each other about it,” Hayworth responded with the answer Jack feared most, he would have much rather Hayworth just told him to disinvite Mark.

“Right. I suppose we should probably do that at some point,” Jack said with a sigh. Hayworth gave him a glance before continuing his writing and smiling.

“Although I suppose if that doesn’t work, you’ll just have to outplay him in the game on Friday,” Hayworth said with a smirk, getting a small laugh out of Jack. Before they could continue, the sound of a ringing bell alerted the two to the end of Jack’s free period, and Hayworth promptly stood up and gave Jack a solid slap on the shoulder.

"Welp, that's our cue! Wouldn't want to be late to class," Hayworth said with a chuckle, though he seemed to be talking more passed Jack than to him at this point. Jack stood up with the big man and gave a quick 'thank you' before exiting into the school halls.

The large building stood to be four stories, not including the basement, and to Jack seemed more akin to a university hall than a high school building, though he supposed that everything in Lion's Hill was in excess. That was the natural result of living in a predominantly upper class town after all. As Jack made his way through the Victorian halls of the building, greeted with a smile by every other student he passed on his way to class, his drifting mind was interrupted by a tap on his shoulder. He turned to see the familiar face of his best friend, Jeremy Pippins, giving him a big grin.

"You still free to hang tomorrow? Or do you got plans with your girl?" Jeremy asked in a somewhat teasing tone, pushing up his glasses with his back knuckles to stave them from slipping off his face. Jack snickered softly and shook his head, continuing towards his next class, his backpack slung loosely around one shoulder.

"Nah man, she's got plans with her family tomorrow night," Jack said with a chuckle, looking straight ahead at the classroom before the two.

"So then, I'll catch you and Mark at my place at 5 alright? We can grab some pizza at that place you like!" Jeremy said as he turned towards his class.

"Yea, sure thing, sounds like a plan," Jack responded with a smile, ignoring his apprehension in the hopes that Mark would just be too busy to hang out. Jeremy gave a smile and a wave as he headed off to class by himself, leaving Jack to his thoughts.

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An old but refined dark oak manor stood atop the hill, cast gray in the dim evening light. Despite the excessive elegance of the neighborhood, it was still arranged in the style of an average suburb, the immaculacy of each individual house looking no more out of place than a tree in a forest. Letting his sneakers hit the cool hard concrete below him, Jack stepped off his bike and made his way up the long steep pathway to the front door. The front yard was decorated with various flora and wildlife he still could yet remember the name of, and as he took step after step towards the brass knocker on the front door, he pondered the purpose of owning a pathway so exhausted to walk up. Before he could reach for the knocker, the door swung open to reveal

the smiling face of Lucille, Jack's mother, clearly just as ecstatic to see her youngest child as always.

"Hello honey, how was school today?" she said with a smile as Jack parked his bike in the garage and smiled softly back at her.

"It was alright, I wasn't so sure about my math test though. I probably should've studied more for it," Jack replied in a timid tone, knowing that he had forgoed studying for the test entirely in lieu of hanging out with Haley behind the bleachers.

"Oh I'm sure you did just fine," his mother said with a wave, disregarding any of the more realistic worries Jack may have had. "Now come in here and have dinner, you look famished!"

Pale golden light showered the dining room from the chandelier above, the table below being stacked with a vast array of meats and pastries. A whole roast turkey sat on a silver tray in the middle of the table, wading in the river of gravy beneath it. Jack's plate was piled high with food that he knew he wouldn't be able to eat, but he also knew his parents would complain about him being wasteful if he didn't make the appearance of eating a lot.

"Jeremy and I are planning on getting dinner tomorrow night if that's ok with you guys," Jack said with a smile.

"Oh of course hun! It is your birthday week after all," his mother replied in a cheery voice, taking a few slices of turkey for herself.

"So son, are you excited for your big day this Friday?" a gruff older voice asked from the opposite end of the table. Jack looked up from his food at his old man, Abraham. Abe's hair had streaks of gray despite the copious amounts of black dye he used, and the dress suit he always

wore seemed far too formal for a family dinner, but Jack supposed that was par for the course when it came to the town as a whole.

"Yea, I guess so," Jack said with a nod, circling around his thoughts for a few moments longer until he knew exactly how to put them. His mother looked up at him with a soft giggle.

"You guess so? Come on Jack, you have to be more excited than that, eighteen is an important age for a growing boy like you," she said with a smile as she bit into a slice of turkey. Jack rolled his eyes and looked down at his food, hoping his mother wasn't trying to imply that this year was special because he'd finally be able to have sex.

"Right, I uhh... I guess I am pretty excited about it," Jack said with a bit more confidence, hoping that this response would shift the topic of conversation off of him. In truth, he was rather looking forward to Friday. Not for the party, but for the big game that day. Jack figured that perhaps winning a game of baseball would make him feel less guilty about people celebrating him.

"Well your father and I are certainly looking forward to it, we're gonna have the ballroom set up with—" The sound of a clearing throat interrupted Lucille mid-thought. She glanced over at Abe, who finished chewing his food and gave her a hardy chuckle, one which she returned with one of much lighter tone. "Oh my yes, I wouldn't want to spoil the whole thing now would I?" Jack let out a small laugh with his parents, nodding along softly as he planned the most polite way to ask to leave the table. Before he could however, the sound of the creaking front door alerted the family to the belated entrance of Jack's elder sister, Evelyn.

"You're late again young lady," Abe barked out in a refined but strict tone. Evelyn entered the dining room, still wearing her school uniform from early that day, the top two buttons undone along with her neck scarf being pulled too loose.

"Sorry dad, but Angela's mom is still refusing to let her use the car, so I had to walk all the way home," she said in a somewhat tired, but still confident voice. Jack could foresee a larger argument being made out of this insignificant scuffle, so with the scratching of his chair legs on the wood floor, he excused himself from the table to his bedroom.

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He awoke in a hot sweat, his heart pounding hard in his chest as he felt blood rush through his veins. He had that same dream again. He could still hear the shouting of his parents and the thunderous cracks of rifle fire. Jack laid back in his bed, taking deep breaths in an effort to calm himself from the nightmare he had just experienced. A cool breeze squeezed itself through the bottom crack of his bedside window, accompanied by a splash of moonlight blocked out by his closed curtains. He reached a hand over to the desk beside his bed, its pale skin touching the cool surface of an empty glass. With a glance, Jack confirmed the state of his water glass. Letting out a disappointed sigh, Jack removed himself from the warm safety of his bedding and stepped his feet onto the cool wood of his floorboards.

Making special effort not to step on any of the particularly creaky floorboards, Jack made his way to the bathroom on the second floor, just two doors past the imperial staircase leading into the foyer. As the first floor made its way into his view however, he could see a light out of the corner of his eye. It must've been at least 2 or 3 in the morning, Jack thought to himself, why would anyone else be up at this hour. Maybe it was his sister getting a late night snack? But the light wasn't coming from the kitchen, it was coming from underneath the closed door to the ballroom. With an uneasy gate, Jack slowly descended the staircase, cautioning against any hint

of himself he may make apparent with his presence. His feet landing on the landing, Jack drifted over to the closed door, lowering himself to be eye level with the keyhole.

It took a moment for his eyes to adjust to the sharp contrast in lighting, but once they did, his curiosity only grew. The ballroom had always seemed like a lonely room to Jack, too much open space with not enough furniture, he felt rather agoraphobic even just looking in at that moment. Jack took a quiet gulp as his eyes fixated on the outset of the room. His parents said they were planning on setting it up for his birthday, but the layout of the chairs seemed more like a classroom than a party. There were rows of fold-out chairs, all circling around the middle of the room, in which sat a single seat. Was that seat supposed to be his, Jack wondered. The thought of him literally being the center of attention made his stomach churn as he grew even more weary of the upcoming party. But the strange setup of the room itself was not what caught Jack's attention, it was the people inside it that did. He could make out two taller figures, presumably his mother and father, along with a shorter one, his sister. But that's not what made his heart skip a beat. Standing besides the three, too obstructed by distance to be made out with any reasonable degree of certainty. There was a fourth person.

Chapter 2

Wednesday, June 2nd - 2 days until Jack's birthday

Beads of hot sweat dripped down Jack's forehead as he stood on third base, knees bent, figure tilted towards home. Rays of heat beat down on the field from the blazing sun above, its onslaught unperturbed by the cloudless sky. As much as Jack enjoyed baseball, the threat of heat exhaustion had always made him a little hesitant to play on warmer days. The sharp crack of a bat jolted him from his thoughts, and Jack sent himself bolting down to home base. Sand kicked

up into the air with each deliberate step, the sound of his thumping heart overpowering any potential advice his team may have been yelling at him. In front of him stood one of his teammates, Noah Bullsworth, feet firmly placed on home plate, reaching out a gloved hand to catch the incoming baseball. Noah was big for his age, more intimidating than his skill perhaps warranted, but intimidating he was nonetheless. Perhaps that's why coach kept him on the team, it'd explain why he never seemed to play outside of practice games like this one. Seems like a bit of a waste to have your biggest player be a benchwarmer, but maybe that way the other teams never got a chance to see how painfully average he was given his large stature. It keeps up the facade of danger without ever showing your hand, Jack thought.

With a sharp breath, he gathered himself. Jack slid straight into home plate just as the ball flew straight into Noah's mitt. A cloud of dust flew up from the dirt below, obscuring Jack's vision for a moment and speckling his jersey with dark tan.

"Safe!" a voice rang out from his right, allowing Jack to let out a sigh of relief as he could hear cheering from the dugout, accompanied by a familiar whistle from the stands. Jack peeked his head up from the ground to see a lone figure, sitting on the bottom-most seat of the stands and clapping excitedly for him. Her light gold bangs flowed down to her shoulders, accentuated by the deep blue of her school uniform. She smiled at Jack, who quickly popped up from the ground and jogged over to her as the rest of his team continued with their scrimmage.

"H-hey Haley!" Jack stammered out, still out of breath from the game. Haley looked at her bedraggled boyfriend with a smile, standing up and stepping down to be at eye-level with him.

"Hey Haley," she mimicked back in a dorkish voice with a giggle. "Gosh, you expect me to believe you're a star athlete with that kind of greeting?" The two laughed at her comment and Jack took a moment to catch his breath before responding.

"Well, I guess I'm not your typical star athlete then," Jack said, inwardly cringing at how lame of a response he felt that was. Haley giggled at it anyways, relieving Jack of any potential embarrassment. Even though they had only known each other for a few months at that point, Jack felt more comfortable around Haley than he did most others. No matter how lame his jokes or pick-up lines were, Haley always seemed to find his clumsy ineptitude charming, which provided Jack with an immense amount of relief in social situations. In fact, were it not for meeting her all those months back, Jack would've probably still been moping around in his room all day, too anxious to do anything overly social.

"So then, you ready to have dinner with my parents tomorrow?" Haley asked with a boyish grin, supposedly already knowing the answer. Jack groaned and let his head fall back, exhausted at the thought.

"I guess so," Jack said with a sigh.

"Oh come on, it won't be that bad! They can't wait to meet you!" Haley said with an excited smile.

"Well... can't they just meet me at my birthday party then? At least that way they'll be too busy talking to everyone else to see how awkward I am," Jack said with an embarrassed chuckle. Haley smiled and rolled her eyes, reaching out and grabbing his dirtied and blistered hand with her soft, warm one.

"They'll love you Jack, don't worry about it. And trust me, it'll be much easier for them to meet you over dinner than at your birthday." She covered her mouth with her free hand to let out

another giggle, and Jack smiled. He supposed she was right. After all, he couldn't think of anyone he knew who hated him, not openly at least. He felt her soft lips touch his cheek as she gave him a comforting kiss, and with that he felt his worries slowly melt away. Haley smiled and stepped back, grabbing her backpack and looking at the hand she had used to hold his, now peppered with grim and dirt.

"Maybe just remember to take a shower before you come tomorrow night," she said with a grin as she turned to leave.

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Unlike the afternoon before it, the evening air was cool and dry, sun set behind the hills at the edge of town. The buzzing of a neon sign filled the void of silence with a calming familiar, if artificial, hum. Jack leaned back in his seat, biting into a slice of piping hot pizza, too hungry to be bothered by the burning feeling of just melted cheese on the roof of his mouth. Jeremy and Mark sat across from him doing the same, Jeremy being a bit more cautious with his slice as a result of being burnt one too many times. With a swig of his soda, Mark stood up with a grunt and stretched.

"I'll be right back. Gotta hit the bathroom." In a moment, Mark's long strides took him from the table to around a corner, towards the back of the restaurant. Jeremy snickered softly and looked up at Jack as he finished his second slice.

"You want my second slice? I'm not all that hungry," Jeremy said through a full mouth, pushing his plate closer to Jack. Jack did not respond however, for he was deep in thought about the night previous.

"Hey... Jeremy," Jack began, his gaze focused on the blue and red neon light that flashed the words 'OPEN' repeatedly, on the outside of the restaurant's face. "You mind if I tell you something kinda weird?" Jeremy looked up from the plate he had been slowly pushing, now closer to Jack than he. He nodded slowly, before realizing that Jack's vision wasn't anywhere near him.

"Uhh, sure thing man," he said, gulping down his pizza and taking a bite of the crust.

"Well, I'm not really sure what to make of it, and I'm not entirely sure it even happened, since it was really late and I could've just been dreaming I guess. But, I woke up really late last night, and I oversaw my parents and sister talking to someone in our house." Jeremy's chewing ceased for a brief moment, before continuing along as normal.

"What do you mean? Like, a maid or electrician or something?" he asked in his usual monotone voice, seemingly not giving the incident too much thought.

"No, I mean, I don't think so. They looked like a teenager, and they were in the ballroom. The ballroom was set up super weird too, there were like, chairs in a circle and in the middle there was—" Jack was cut off by the sound of a swinging door, and the re-entrance of Mark. Jack was afraid of Mark overhearing their conversation, given that he would most likely just make fun of Jack for getting so worked up over what probably wasn't much of a big deal.

"Meh, sounds to me like they just wanna plan your party in secret, makes sense to me," Jeremy said as he took a sip of his juice, Mark sitting down at the table's end before continuing with his meal. "You didn't overhear anything they were saying right?" Jeremy asked, bringing Jack's attention to him.

"No, they were too far away," Jack said softly, hoping not to peak Mark's interest. Jeremy smiled and shrugged.

"Well then like I said, probably was just some birthday planning thing," Jeremy said as he finished the last few pieces of his crust. Jack sighed softly and nodded. Maybe he hadn't properly explained the situation to Jeremy, or maybe he was just being paranoid about it, it was often hard to tell which for Jack. Mark glanced over at Jack and smiled, patting him on the shoulder.

"So, big one eight's comin' up huh?" Mark said with a grin, his pats feeling more like smacks than anything. Jack nodded, trying to hide a grimace from his peer.

"Right, I assume you'll be too busy to come?" Jack said, hopeful that Mark would respond in the positive.

"Of course not dick head! I wouldn't miss it for the world," Mark said with a smirk, picking up the crumbs that remained on his plate. He glanced down to see Jeremy's unfinished plate in front of Jack and chuckled softly, pulling it closer to himself and picking up the slice. Jeremy cleared his throat and glared at Mark.

"Umm, Mark? I gave that slice to JACK. Ya know, so HE could eat it?" Jeremy said, staring a hole through Mark. Mark took a bite of the slice and shrugged, motioning to Jack.

"He never finishes his meal, what makes ya think he'd be able to finish yours," Mark said with a chuckle. Jack glanced between the two of them nervously. Jeremy seriously looked like he was about to deck Mark in the face, he had never seen him this mad before, and over a slice of pizza?

"I-it's ok man. He's right, I'm not that hungry anyways..." Jack said softly, shrinking back into his seat, wanting to avoid a confrontation between the two. Maybe Jeremy was being more reasonable than he thought, Mark didn't even ask Jack what he wanted ahead of time, not that he ever does. Jeremy glanced over at Jack, still fuming, before letting out a sigh and leaning back, giving Mark a look as the three finished dinner.

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Standing out in the cool summer breeze, Jack took a deep breath as he leaned against the tall oak tree outside his house. He enjoyed these moments of serene silence more than anything, a break from the hustle and bustle of regular life. No one to talk to. He didn't have to think or worry about how he held himself, or how others would perceive the placement of his hands. He supposed he felt similarly around Haley, and Jeremy to some extent as well, but as of right now, he got to be all alone, even if just for a few moments. The glass of the foyer window illuminated with a bright yellow light, and Jack supposed that was the cue for his loitering to come to a close. With a short breath, Jack made his way up to the mansion before him.

"Hello sweetie." Lucille greeted him with a loving smile, wearing an apron with her long brown hair tied back into a bun. "Here, let me take your backpack. I baked some cookies special for my big man!" she said with a giggle as she took his bag away and started ushering him into the kitchen before he could object. Jack wasn't all that hungry, but to his mother's credit, she did make some great desserts. "So, how was your night out with friends?" she said with a smile as she placed the tray of baked treats down on the table in front of him, fresh from the oven. Jack shrugged as he took one of the cookies, making sure it wasn't too hot before taking a bite.

"It was pretty good, we just played games at Jeremy's house for a while before getting pizza out," Jack said with a shrug as he leaned back in his chair. His mother smiled happily as she put another batch of cookies in the oven, moving to the fridge to grab Jack a tall glass of milk.

"Hopefully Mark didn't bother you too much," she said with a giggle, placing the class down on the table for him. Jack shook his head as he took a sip, before pausing.

"What do you mean?" he said slowly, sitting up a bit in his chair. Lucille seemed to slow for a moment before responding.

"I'm just saying, I know Mark can be a bit much. Like, he can be a bit rude sometimes. Especially to nice kids like you," she said, turning around to give him a big smile. Jack thought for a moment, weighing his options, before nodding.

"R-right, I guess he can," he responded, leaning back in his seat for a moment before pushing his chair back and standing up. "Well, I should probably head upstairs, I wanna get a lot of rest for my dinner with Haley tomorrow night." His mother turned back to give him a slightly disappointed look.

"Really? But we just started talking, plus you've barely finished any of the cookies and I just put in another batch," she said in a disheartened tone. Jack turned away from his mother and bit his lip, trying to keep his composure.

"We can talk more tomorrow morning, I'm just really tired right now," he said, forcing a yawn as he made his way upstairs, trying not to let his mother guilt him into staying down there and distracting him from his thoughts. Lucille said something akin to 'have a good night', or 'sleep well', but Jack was too perturbed to respond with anything more than a 'you too'. While he had never talked directly to his parents about his dislike and annoyance with Mark, it was entirely possible that it was something they were able to just assume, Mark wasn't exactly the most subtle person in the world. However, what disturbed Jack more than any possible knowledge of his inner feelings, feelings which he may have well expressed in the past without knowing it, was that he never said he had hung out with Mark that night.

Chapter 3

Thursday, June 3rd - 1 day until Jack's birthday

A wrapping on the door's hard wood frame jolted Hayworth from his half-slumber. The slightly rotund man sat up in his chair and cleared his throat before greeting his uninvited guest.

"Come in," he said with a grunt as he adjusted his tie, wiping the crust from his groggy eyes. The door opened with a slow creak as Jack made his way into the office, holding himself a tad more rigid than he usually did. The boy's stature seemed to be a defensive one, portraying himself as taller in an effort to exude confidence, but confidence was never Jack's forte.

"Jack, my boy! To what do I owe the pleasure of this surprise visit?" Hayworth asked in a jovial hum, outstretching his arms as he motioned for Jack to sit down. Jack did as he was told, plopping himself down in the cushiony armchair parallel to the school therapist. He mulled over his words once again, trying to decipher the best way to obtain the information he so desired. He had prepared himself for this conversation all night, however now that he was actually sitting in front of Hayworth, the words couldn't seem to come out.

"I think... umm..." he began, his mouth moving like molasses, his tongue suddenly feeling as if it were made of sandpaper. Hayworth leaned forward slightly, raising his eyebrows as he awaited Jack's inquiry. Images flashed through Jack's head, and for a split moment, he saw four figures, standing and speaking in a hushed whisper in the middle of the ballroom at midnight. "I think... I'm worried about losing the baseball game tomorrow." Hayworth's curious expression turned into one of bemusement as he smiled and nodded in agreement.

"I see, well that's a perfectly understandable thing to worry about Jack! I'm sure all your teammates feel the same way. Hell, I'm sure Jackie Robinson felt the same way before each

game," Hayworth said with a chuckle. Jack gave him a soft smile in return, putting on a sense of relief as his frame relaxed.

"Right, I guess I'm just getting into my head about this stuff," Jack said with a relieved sigh, both hands resting firmly on his knees to keep his legs from shaking. "Oh and umm... just to make sure sir, everything I tell you stays between us right? I'd just be pretty embarrassed if my parents found out how nervous I can get about this stuff," he said with a chuckle. Hayworth smiled and nodded.

"Of course Jack! Unless I think you're gonna hurt yourself or someone else, everything you say in this room stays in this room," the doctor said with a big smile. Jack nodded, reciprocating the smile, and stood up before his shaking legs could overpower the hands that kept them down on the ground.

"Thanks doctor, I just needed to get that off my chest before the game, and you felt like the best person to talk to," Jack said with a smile as he tried to swiftly but calmly make his way to the door.

"No worries kid, whenever you got something to tell me, I'll be here to hear it," Hayworth said with a hearty chuckle. Jack slipped out of the office before the two could exchange further, and quickly paced down the hall towards the cafeteria for lunch. He could feel a pit forming in his stomach, a worried ball of stress that Hayworth may have seen right through his amateur attempt at gathering information. He would need to tamp that worry down for now however. He would be anxious enough at the dinner tonight.

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The smell of seafood and tomato base filled the large ornate dining room in an unmistakable scent. Jack sat idly at the foot of the table, his heart rattling within his chest as he gazed down at the bowl of half-eaten lobster bisque in front of him. Actually finishing large meals always felt like the hardest thing in the world for him to accomplish, however, his fear of his inappetite being mistaken for distaste with the meal might be just enough to overpower his satiation. He took another sip of the broth as he looked up at the head of the table, at which sat Gregory Barns, Haley's father. With a black suit and frills overtaking his stocky frame, he made Jack feel woefully underdressed. To his left sat Haley's mother, Barbra, wearing a long blue dress with her face perfectly caked in makeup. Jack could definitely see where Haley got her good looks from.

"So Jack, my daughter tells me you plan on becoming a professional baseball player after college," the intimidatingly gruff man before him stated, his cold tone keeping Jack from deciphering any opinions he may have about the fact. Jack finished his bite of lobster and patted his mouth with the cloth napkin he was given before responding.

"Yea- er... yes sir, I do. My parents and I are looking into Stanford University, as they have a good combination of sports and mathematics. But if I don't end up making the cut for their baseball team—" Jack was cut off by the sound of a clearing throat, and he glanced over to see Haley giving him a look. "I mean, if I decide not to pursue baseball, my parents say I'm on track for making it into Harvard, as I am also interested in getting a law degree." Jack finished his short speech, his mouth dry from the talking and his throat sore from the worry. To his surprise, Gregory gave him a somewhat amused look and smiled.

"Well, that is assuming you make it out of highschool," he said with a bemused grin, causing Haley to give him a soft kick from under the table.

"Dad, shush!" she said in a more demanding voice than Jack would've expected a daughter to take with her father. He wasn't all that offended by the old man's joke, but he supposed it was nice that Haley was so defensive of him.

"I was only kidding of course," he said with a gruff laugh, being much more casual than Jack had initially anticipated, "You seem like a brilliant young boy Jack, certainly more so than anyone else who has courted Haley in the past." Haley let out an indignant huff at this comment, though it appeared she didn't have anything to discredit her father's statement. Jack wondered for a split moment whether or not she wanted him to reprimand her father in the same way she did for him, but quickly threw out that idea in favor of shifting the conversation.

"Mr. Barns, you own a logging company right?" The old man shifted his gaze back from his empty bowl to Jack and smiled.

"Why yes I do, I inherited it from my father back in the 60's when he retired, and have been running it ever since," Gregory finished with a self-congratulating smile.

"That's really cool! I admire your hard work a lot sir," Jack said, unsure of how to carry this conversation he started, falling back on the tried and true method of simple flattery. It seemed to work, as Gregory's smile only widened as he continued on about his company. Jack feigned attention as he continued to work on finishing off all his bisque, occasionally glancing up to retrieve a warm smile from Haley. Perhaps he was being foolish to worry about the dinner, and about his birthday by proxy. Jeremy had a point when he said Jack's parents were probably just being secretive about his birthday because they wanted the details of the event to be a surprise; and he supposed it wasn't actually all that much of a stretch for his mom to assume he was hanging out with Mark, it's not like that was all that uncommon of an occurrence. As Jack filled his belly with food and passively listened to Haley's old man talk about his boring logging

company, Jack felt much more calm than he had in a long time. Perhaps this week wouldn't be so bad after all.

Chapter 4

Friday, June 4th - Jack's birthday

A crack of hot summer sweat sliced through the air like a knife through soft butter, the ball shooting straight into the air, accompanied by the mist of dust which was brought up by the bouncing bat on the soft dirt below. Jack felt his feet carry him across the field, kicking up clumps of dust and dirt with each galloping step of his great gait. His eyes were glued to the ground ahead, focus fully set upon his speed, not concerned with whatever base he may land on. Through the commotion of the cheering and shouting from the crowd, his ears strained for a single voice, a single word from his coach. "Home".

With that, Jack flew forward like a man possessed, his visor a blur and his feet alight. He could feel the wind whipping past him, and as his eyes focused on home plate, he could sense a rush of air just past his left ear. Shutting his eyes tight and rushing forward, he slid into home plate, causing a billowing cloud of dust to kick up around him. Jack waited for a moment there, taking fast shallow gulps of air as he waited for his breath to catch up to him. His mind slowed with his body, and vision slowly returned to reveal a foot placed squarely on home plate.

"Safe!" the umpire called out, causing an uproar of excited hoots and hollers from the stands above. Jack's body went numb with this as his heart realized he was still alive after all that, and began beating once again. He could feel the hands of one of his teammates around his shoulders as he was helped to his feet and patted (as well as slapped by some) on the back to accompany their compliments. As Jack stumbled his way back to the dugout, a sense of pride he

was not used to came over him—though this might be more so attributed to the praise he was getting than the actual feat of his actions—but he was happy nonetheless. With a grunt he sat himself back down on the bench next to Bullsworth, who gave him a rough but hearty slap on the shoulder and handed him a bottle of water.

“Good work out there Jackie,” he said with a laugh, molding Jack’s lips into a smile. Letting his body relax and leaning back against the bench, he let the golden rays of sun above dance on his skin and envelope him in a blanket of heat, good heat. His muscles were sore, but he felt complete.

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The locker room was dark and cold. Jack pulled off his sweat stained jersey and threw on a somewhat more comfortable button down shirt, hearing the slamming of a metal locker behind him as the last of his teammates left the building. Closing the locker door for the last time that week and pulling on his bag, Jack turned towards the room’s exit prepared to make his way back home. A figure blocked his path.

“Oh— uhh... hey Mark. I didn’t know anyone else was still here,” he said with a somewhat nervous chuckle, trying not to reveal how startled he was by Mark’s presence out of sheer embarrassment.

“Hey Jack.” Mark replied in an uncharacteristically soft tone, his hands held firmly in his jacket pockets, “I just wanted to say... ya know, happy birthday.” Jack felt a mixture of shock, worry, and gratitude, but was more confused than anything else.

“T-thanks... I guess,” Jack replied with a skittish laugh, unsure of how else to respond. Mark approached him in a somewhat stilted manner, seemingly somehow more uncomfortable with the situation than Jack; his hands fidgeted in his pockets.

“I wanted to give you your present early. I know you’ve gone hunting with your dad before and... I thought you could use this.” His hand slowly extended and Jack felt his blood run cold as his hand released itself from the confines of his pocket. In it was held a small handgun, plated with ivory and silver. Jack stood in place, jaw clenched as he stared at the weapon, before slowly extending a hand to take it. While it was true he had gone hunting with his dad, it was also true that he himself was afraid of guns; though that fear was perhaps trumped by one other: the fear of being rude.

“T-thanks man...” Jack said with baited apprehension, slowly reaching out to take the gun from his perhaps friend. Somehow, despite all his apprehension, Mark seemed like he might have been more nervous about this encounter than Jack. With a quick nod, Mark turned and walked out of the room, leaving Jack all alone. He tilted his head to peer over the gun once more, he had no idea the type of model, best he could make out was a revolver of some sort. With slight apprehension, he flicked open the ____, relieved to see the gun was at least unloaded. He stood there for another moment or so, taking in all that had just happened, before putting the revolver in his back pocket and grabbing his bag to go back home, nervous but excited for the birthday party.

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The sky had turned a dark black, ignited by a cascade of stars. Jack felt his sneakers touch to the cold pavement with each step, his body still exhausted from the events of the day, and his mind still flooded with dopamine from his victory. He made his way down Baker Lane, soft burning lamplight, filling his sight like sunspots in the night. He could hear a soft hum of noise coming from the direction of his house, seems like the party was beginning without him.

“Hey there birthday boy,” a voice called out from ahead. Jack felt himself jump a little before glancing forward, seeing the face of man he had a passing recognition with. A policeman stood before him, leaning casually against his cop car, his mustached lips curled into a smile. “Are ya looking forward to your party?” Jack stood still for a moment, his heart unsure whether to beat calm or fast.

“Uhh... y-yea... I guess,” Jack said timidly, unsure of what else to say. Jack had seen the officer around before, but he had never approached Jack in such a casual and confident manner. It almost seemed as if the officer was just waiting for something.

Before Jack could get another word out, he felt the buzz of a phone in his pocket. He quickly slid it out to see a message from Haley: *Go in through the garage when you get to your house, I got a little birthday present for you ;).* Jack felt his cheeks flush a bit as he looked up nervously at the officer, who maintained that same uncanny smile. The officer gave him a slight nod as he moved to get into his car, calling out, “See ya around Jack.” Jack stood still as the officer drove away, his mind a flood of confused and uncertain thoughts. He glanced back down at the message he had gotten, and felt his feet begin to carry him down the road towards the party.

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The sound of classical music echoed from the inside of the mansion, and down the hill it sat atop of. It seemed far too fancy for an eighteen year old's birthday party, but at this point it didn't surprise Jack. Golden light shined from the windows of the house, illuminating several figures in each pane, talking and laughing amongst themselves. His heart fluttered as his feet shifted towards the house's connected garage, knocking softly on the garage door with his eyes planted firmly on the painted steel before him. A soft mechanical whirring sounded out as the door began to slowly raise, and Jack took a step back, the image of a giddy Haley in the room alone with a single chair appearing before him. Jack hesitated a moment before stepping in, more confused than anything else.

"Hey Haley, you uhh... wanted to show me something?" Jack got out in a voice more nervous than he intended. Haley let out a soft giggle as she walked over to Jack and began unbuttoning his shirt.

"Just go sit down on the chair big guy," she said softly, causing Jack's heart to race a little as he quickly nodded in agreement, doing as she said. He dropped himself down onto the chair, his shirt open as the garage door slowly closed again, Haley making her way over to him. Jack's breath quickened, moving a bit in the seat as he awaited whatever she had planned. He saw her figure move past him, and as he tried turning around to watch her she spoke in a soft but commanding voice, "No peeking. We wouldn't wanna ruin the surprise now would we?" Jack quickly faced forward once again, his nerves on fire with excitement as he tried to remain patient. "Now close your eyes," she said with a giggle as she approached from behind, Jack doing so with bated breath. He could feel a soft pressure around his chest and arms, along with her smooth hands on his skin. "Ok, now open your eyes," she spoke in a prideful tone, moving

back to the front of the room. Jack did so, seeing her standing before him, then glancing down to see a set of ropes tying him to the chair. For a moment his heart paused, stuck between excitement and confusion, if Haley was into this sorta thing, she had never expressed it to him, nor him to her. Before his mind could continue, he saw her soft smile turn into a sinister smirk, as she tilted her head and let out a soft laugh. “God, you were so easy.”

That same mechanical whirring resonated once again as the garage door slowly began to open, and the world seemed to turn red. Tens of people stood before him, his family, friends, classmates. A figure stepped forward, a small somewhat rotund man, wearing a suit and partially undone tie.

“Jack, my boy!” Dr. Hayworth called out with a smile, opening up his arms as if to provide some sense of comfort to the situation. Jack tried to move his arms, but they were tied tight to the chair, keeping him in place for all to see. The doctor continued towards him, as did the rest of the crowd, all smiling and jeering. His parents stepped forward, both taking a position on either side of him, their hands on his shoulders proudly as he continued to struggle against his restraints. His sister remained in the crowd, simply smiling and watching.

“M-mom! D-dad? What the hell is happening?” Jack yelled out, his heart thumping against his chest hard, threatening to burst out. His mother tilted her head down to him, smiling sickly sweet as Dr. Hayworth stood in front of him.

“Don’t worry hun, this is all part of the process,” she said in a calm and caring manner, rubbing his shoulder gently as he squirmed in his seat. Another figure stepped forward from the crowd, Jeremy Pippins, giving him a big grin, and holding out a butcher's knife in his hands. Jack felt his heart stop as he saw this, his body tightening with fear. Dr. Hayworth took the knife from

Jeremy with a smile, touching the blade lightly to his finger before shifting his focus to Jack's exposed stomach.

"What the fuck is going on! Someone fucking help me!" Jack screamed out to the crowd, his eyes darting back and forth between the people he's known all his life, glancing back to his parents once more. They were smiling the widest.

"Oh Jack, you still don't get it do you," Dr. Hayworth said with a chuckle.

"Get what!? What the fuck do you mean?" Jack spat out, still trying hopelessly to escape his bindings.

"Well if you must know," the doctor continued in a calm tone, Jack's blood running cold as he lowered the blade to his chest, "Every eighteen years, one family is chosen to raise a child. That child is primed and pampered their whole life until their eighteenth birthday, why else do you think people seem to like you so much?" Hayworth let out a laugh as Jack felt his limbs go numb and looked up to his parents.

"M-mom... dad... i-is this true...?" Jack stammered out to the seeming hilarity of several of the bystanders.

"I mean... yea. It is," his dad chuckled out, reaching down to pat Jack's belly. "We were never able to get you to eat as much as we wanted though." As his father spoke, Jack's body tensed up and he could feel his breath catch in the back of his throat.

"W-what..?" was the only thing Jack was able to get out before he felt the blade of the butcher's knife slice into his chest, leaving a deep gash as a deep crimson river began to flow out of it. Hayworth quickly got on his knees and put his mouth to the opening, lapping up the blood that flowed out like a wild animal, the rest of the bystanders began walking forward, their eyes lighting up with eager anticipation. Jack screamed out in pain as teeth gnawed at his skin, the

color draining from his body, following the blood. Tongues of boiling water on the snow of his skin, melting him away. A shout from Abraham brought the mob of hounding mouths away from Jack's body, his breath strained as his vision blurred. Abe stepped forward in front of Jack, meeting his gaze with a smile more animated than he had ever given his son before.

"D-Dad... p-please..." Jack sputtered out, struggling to maintain his breath let alone fight the binds that kept him in place. Abraham ruffled Jack's hair with a smirk, running his finger across his wound to lick up the remaining blood.

"Don't worry kid, we're not gonna kill you. You'd stop producing blood for us if we did." He spoke in an almost jovial tone, that damn smile still plastered on his face. He could feel the ropes around him fall to the floor as his mother untied them and forced him to his feet by the scruff of his neck. "While we could cut you up and have one great feast, we've found that it's much more rewarding to keep you alive for a month or so while your body continues to produce blood, then feast," Abe continued, almost more so to himself than to Jack. At this point, Jack would rather they had just killed him. The heat of several bodies surrounded him, and he could see several of the younger children licking up his blood from the floor. He was pushed and pulled forward, his body limp and lifeless as he felt the adrenaline rushing through his veins slowly begin to dissipate. His eyes drifted back to the crowd following him as he was dragged out into the warm night air. From his parents to his sister, Hayworth to Haley, Jeremy to Noah, Gregory to Barbra, Mark to...

Jack's eyes lit up as he felt a surge of energy run through his body, pushing back against his mother's grip and stumbling forward before pulling out the revolver from his back pocket and pointing it at her. The crowd suddenly went silent, their hollers cutting off as they moved back slowly as a collective. The gun was unloaded, just a facade, but the mob of hungry blue-bloods

didn't know that, and Jack wasn't about to show his hand. His eyes shot from one face to another, then to Mark, whose eyes were planted firmly on the ground, a slight smile on his face; not one of malice or contempt, but one of meager pride.

"D-don't fucking move!" Jack spat out, slowly continuing to back away from the crowd, no one person wanting to chase after him. Jack quickly glanced behind himself to see a line of houses, followed by a line of houses, followed by the outskirts of the forest. Keeping the gun pointed at the crowd, Jack feebly limped his way backwards, the air stinging his gash as drops of blood continued to drip down onto the grass below. Once he passed the overly-long threshold of the house's yard, he turned and booked it towards the treeline, a few people from the crowd moving to run after him, but most staying put. The town was illuminated by the full moon above, and heavy mist began to set in.

Epilogue

Friday, June 5th - 266 days until a new child is born

The day was beautiful, not too many clouds, but enough to have some shade. Evelyn sat on the porch with her mother, drinking tea and eating toast. The two looked down as a group of police cars made their way towards the woods, Abraham sitting on the other side of the porch in his rocking chair, reading from the day's paper.

"Hey Eve, you know this Jessica girl right?" Abe said as he squinted at the paper and took a sip from his coffee mug.

"She's like, my best friend, dad. Of course I know her!" she said, slightly indigent and annoyed.

“I thought Angela was your best friend dear,” Lucille said as he took another bite of toast, watching a second group of police cars drive past them.

“Huh? No way, Angela and I are totally over,” Evelyn said with a scoff, leaning back in her chair.

“Well whoever she is, says here that she’s been chosen as the next host, along with some boy Raphael?” Evelyn let out a short laugh, taking another sip.

“*Him?* Oh boy... that relationship is gonna be something.” Evelyn laughed out, stretching her back with a grunt.

“Oh don’t be so quick to judge hun, your father and I got much closer after having you!” Lucille objected with a kind smile.

“Yea, but you guys didn’t *have* to have me,” Evelyn protested, sitting back up and finishing off her breakfast. “Whatever, hope he isn’t too much for her,” she said before going back inside, leaving her parents alone on the porch. Abraham let out a deep sigh as he folded up the newspaper and placed it on the table before him, taking another sip of coffee. Lucille slowly stood and walked to his side, placing a hand on his shoulder as the two gazed out at the forest, watching as a group of men gathered up their rifles and marched into the trees.